down into smaller quantities, concealed, camouflaged and shipped to India," says a senior NCB official.

Ashish Bhatia, former director general of police, Gujarat, says, "The Union home ministry has issued strict instructions to have zero tolerance to drugs. We have been on hyper alert for the past two years." All hands are on deck: almost half of all district SOGs, the ATS, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), local police, the NCB, Coast Guard (CG), Navy and their intelligence wings. "The DRI has helped us in seizures coming from ports like Kandla, Mundra and Pipavav, and CG has busted several drug transport ships on the high seas. We have regular virtual meetings with heads of these agencies of all western states, which are sometimes attended by the state's chief ministers too," says Bhatia. Also, the senior NCB official adds, "Now that Indian probe agencies have tightened controls, usage of India as a transit route is also reducing."

Funding is another aspect that investigating agencies are hoping to tighten the noose around. "We are going to the root of funding in each case, which has led us to conduct raids in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Delhi and Kolkata. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) is investigating funding in two cases," says Bhatia. He points to the danger of the drug trade facilitating the entry of Fake Indian Currency Notes (FICN) into the market. Cryptocurrencies are also used for drug transactions. "We have traced crypto transactions from California to New Zealand."

Where the investigating agencies fumble is the NDPS Act itself. "The commercial quantity of MD is 50 gm. That means a person possessing this quantity shall be jailed for at least 10 years. Ganja's commercial quantity is 20 kg," says NCB Ahmedabad zonal director Shailendra Mishra. So stringent are the pre-arrest procedures of the NDPS Act that non-NCB officials are scared of invoking it. A senior officer in the Gujarat police admits that prior to 2018, the local police did not register drug-related cases under the NDPS Act. Officers of the NCB say that one wrong move in registering a case under the NDPS Act can jeopardise the case and invite strictures, which makes the police apprehensive. Investigators, thus, always have an eye on the big traffickers, or, in the case of MD, manufacturers. "After the Union Home ministry's directive, state agencies got training from NCB to file cases under the NDPS Act as the intelligence network of the local police is robust," says the officer. The increased efficiency of the investigating agencies could be one reason why more drug-related cases are coming to light.

However, while action is welcome, every bust leads to an increase in the street price of contraband, putting further stress on addicts. Mishra advocates a three-pronged approach to safeguard society from drugs: supply, harm and demand. While supply reduction is interdiction, harm reduction is about rehabilitation. The most important task, however, is demand reduction. "As long as there is demand, supply will find a way. Sensitising the youth, particularly in schools and colleges, is the most effective way to counter drug abuse," he says.

Can Gujarat cope with the Mephedrone scourge? Perhaps, but it's not seizures alone that will cut it. The real rot runs far deeper. ■

A NUMBER OF MEPHEDRONE ADDICTS TURN DRUG PEDDLERS THEMSELVES TO SUSTAIN THEIR ADDICTION

MD: A FACT SHEET

Mephedrone, or MD, is a stimulant psychotropic substance, which was banned in India in 2015 under the NDPS Act. It is mostly available in white powdered form, sometimes as tablets or capsules, and is usually ingested orally or snorted. **A designer drug,** or a New Psychoactive Substance (NPS)—products designed to recreate the effects of banned natural drugs as substitutes—its effects are similar to cocaine and ecstasy. Investigators also call it the 'poor man's cocaine'

EFFECTS
Mephedrone is a classic 'upper' drug. It increases blood pressure and makes the consumer feel euphoric, more sociable, empathetic, alert and aroused. As the effects wear off, the consumer may experience depression, anxiety, irritability and insomnia. MD also leads to gastrointestinal complications and loss of appetite

THE ORIGIN
The chemical formula of MD was first recorded in a French medical journal in 1929, according to the European Monitoring Centre for Drugs and Drug Addiction. But its potential as an NPS was discovered around 2003 by a group of underground chemists. The discovery went viral globally. Around 2004, a group in Israel is believed to have first started mass manufacturing MD as capsules. The concept went viral in the UK around 2009 as MD replaced cocaine as a party drug. Since it was not banned, the industry thrived due to legal gaps, with MD being sold as 'plant food' or 'fertiliser'

PUNISHMENT
The commercial quantity of MD in India is 50 grams, which means a person found in possession of this quantity is deemed a trafficker or peddler, and can be jailed for 10 to 20 years under the NDPS Act

PRICE
The street price of MD is Rs 1,000-Rs 3,000 per gram in India, while it may go up to Rs 10,000 per gram in the international market. In comparison, cocaine's street price in India is upwards of Rs 3,000. The most expensive drug in the market currently is black cocaine, sold at Rs 20,000 per gram